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Source: *Research in Phenomenology*, 2022, Vol. 52, No. 1 (2022), pp. 84-119

Published by: Brill

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.2307/27346989>

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Self-Consciousness without an “I”: A Critique of Zahavi’s Account of the Minimal Self

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*In memory of Steven Kupfer
22nd April 1941–29th March 2021*

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Abstract

This paper takes Zahavi’s view to task that every conscious experience involves a “minimal sense of self.” Zahavi bases his claim on the observation that experience, even on the pre-reflective level, is not only about the object, but also has a distinctive qualitative aspect which is indicative of the fact that it is *for me*. It has the quality of what he calls “for-meness” or “mineness.” Against this I argue that there are not two phenomena but only one. On the pre-reflective level, experience is transparent. Conscious experience may well be reflexive (insofar as it is relation to me) but this does not imply that I additionally have a sense of what it is like *for me* to have that experience.

I do not just happen to disagree with Zahavi’s account of pre-reflective experience but, more importantly, I am concerned that he imposes it onto his interpretation of Edmund Husserl. Zahavi claims that when Husserl argues that consciousness is necessarily a form of self-consciousness, he must be committed to the view that we necessarily have a sense of ownership. However, Husserl only claims that I am self-conscious but not that I am a self that owns its consciousness. Zahavi thus misses the novelty of Husserl’s position, namely that I do not need to have a sense of abiding ownership, to have experience.

Keywords

Husserl – Kant – Zahavi – non-egological and pre-reflective consciousness – mineness – ownership

When I am angry, there is not just anger in the room, but it is I who am feeling angry. The anger is *mine*. The same holds for my feelings, thoughts and actions; they are all, mine. This is why the much-quoted exchange in Charles Dickens in *Hard Times* sounds so quaint to our ears:

“Are you in pain, dear mother?”

“I think there’s a pain somewhere in the room,” said Mrs. Gradgrind, “but I couldn’t positively say that I have got it.”¹

DICKENS (1969): Book II, Chapter IX: 224

We cannot make sense of Mrs. Gradgrind’s observation, as experience necessarily belongs to someone. When I feel pain, I do not need to find out to whom it belongs, as it is non-criterially, and immediately mine. Does this suggest that there is sense of ownership involved whenever there is experience? Dan Zahavi belongs to a group of thinkers who claims it does (cf. e.g., Levine (2001), Kriegel (2009), Block (2007)). He believes that any experience we have is not only about the object, but also has a distinctive qualitative aspect which is indicative of the fact that it is *for me*. It has the quality of what he calls “for-meness” or “mineness.” What interests Zahavi is *not* that our sense of “what it is like” to taste chocolate is different from remembering tasting it, and that this is different again from “what it is like” to taste ice cream, to act or to entertain thoughts and abstract beliefs (cf. Zahavi (2014): 32). Important for Zahavi is *not* that the *contents* of these experiences differ, but that in *all* these experiences, just like any other possible experience, “something experiential [...] remains the same, namely, their first-personal character.” We are told that “all the different experiences are characterized by a dimension of mineness, or for-me-ness.” In view of this, Zahavi argues that “we should distinguish the plurality of changing experiences from their persisting dative of manifestation” (Zahavi (2014): 19). Zahavi thus believes that whenever we have an experience, we can draw a distinction between “(1) what the object is like for the subject and (2) what the experience of the object is like for the subject” (Zahavi (2014): 33). In other

¹ I am grateful to Jim Grant for reminding me of this passage.

words, when I have pain, it is not only that I feel pain, but there is also a sense of *for-meness* or *mineness*, namely, “what it is like *for me*” to feel the pain.

I remain to be convinced that this is so. While Mrs. Gradgrind’s question sounds queer to our ears because experience necessarily belongs to someone, I do not think that this shows that we are therefore necessarily aware of a specific “for me component.” It is one thing to claim that experience is necessarily *for me* or mine or that it has its dative, but it is quite another to argue that this dative manifests itself, i.e., that experience therefore has a “for-me-ish” or “mine-ly” quality.

Experience, I would like to argue, is transparent. When I cut my finger, I feel a soaring pain. I do not additionally have a sense of what it is like *for me* to feel this pain. I do not just happen to disagree with Zahavi’s account of experience but, more importantly, I am concerned that he imposes it onto his interpretation of Edmund Husserl. Zahavi wishes to show that when Husserl argues that consciousness is necessarily a form of self-consciousness, he must be committed to the view that he is presenting. The problem is, however, that Husserl never discusses the phenomenon of “what it is like for-me” in arguing for his position and, indeed, I believe he does not make room for it either. Husserl refers to different modes of apprehending an object, but not the experience of *what it is like for the subject* to have these different modes of apprehending. Drawing on the notion of “what is it like for me” to have experience in order to explain the nature of self-consciousness, I believe Zahavi does not *explain* or *clarify* Husserl’s position but, if anything, obfuscates it by making it more complex than it need be and, in fact, actually is.

The aim of this paper is not to diminish Zahavi’s invaluable contribution to phenomenology but to offer an alternative interpretation of what it means to be self-conscious. I do not pretend that my reading is necessarily more faithful to Husserl. Husserl’s account of the self and self-consciousness is certainly not uniform or consistent and leaves sufficient room for different interpretations, but I do believe my interpretation to be a more faithful account of what it means to have a sense of self.²

2 This article is part of a larger project which seeks to defend an idealist conception of the self against the so-called “embodied turn” in philosophy. Part of it is in published form. Against the Oxford Naturalists, I, for example, argue that the self cannot be understood as an embodied entity, a person among persons that can be located in the spatial order of the world (Alweiss (2008)). And contrary to Jean-Luc Marion and Michel Henry, who I believe have been influential for Zahavi’s account of the self, I claim that Descartes does not regard embodiment as central to our conception of self (Alweiss 2020).

1 The Non-Egological View of Consciousness (NEC)

My disagreement with Zahavi begins with the way he characterises the development of Husserl's thought. Drawing on the work of Aaron Gurwitsch (see Gurwitsch (1941)), Zahavi argues that Husserl in his early work adopted a non-egological approach to consciousness which he then replaced with an egological one. The non-egological view of consciousness claims that there is no subject of experience, as there is only, as Lichtenberg famously put it, “thinking going on” (see Lichtenberg (1971): 412). The egological view, as Gurwitsch conceives it, in turn, claims that an “I think” must be able to accompany all my representations. The way I understand this claim is that Husserl realised that when we reflect, there needs to be a subject that is conscious of the fact that it is thinking because, in reflection, we combine and compare various representations with one another. To this extent Husserl adopts an egological view of consciousness. However, if I read Zahavi rightly, he wishes to go further and argue that consciousness is egological both on the reflective and pre-reflective level. Zahavi bases this claim on Husserl's realisation that consciousness must necessarily belong to someone and cannot belong to no-one (cf. Zahavi 2021). It is here where I part company with Zahavi. I believe it is one thing to argue that consciousness must belong to someone, and quite another to claim that consciousness egological.

To explain how I arrive at a different interpretation, let me first briefly look at why Husserl initially adopted the non-egological view of consciousness. Husserl maintained that there was no need to appeal “to an additional particular ego-principle which supports all contents and unites them all once again” (LI II v. §4:86), as experience is already unified and structured. Indeed, Husserl thought any appeal to a self to be a hinderance to experience. On the pre-reflective level, experience is transparent: it is world-directed and not self-directed. When I am pre-reflectively engaged in my activities, I am not conscious of myself as a subject of that experience, but my attention is turned to the world and the projects I am involved in. Clearly this is a good thing. If consciousness were a form of self-consciousness, then my attention would always be split. I would not only focus on my project, but I would – at every instant – also be thinking about myself.³ However, when I am repairing a car, singing in the choir, when I am daydreaming, reading a book or solving a mathematical equation, I am not constantly aware of myself as a self or my subjectivity. There

3 As Sartre observed, such a ‘superfluous *I* would be a hindrance. If it existed it would tear consciousness from itself; it would divide consciousness; it would slide into every consciousness like an opaque blade. The transcendental *I* is the death of consciousness’ (Sartre: (1957): 40).

is no underlying reflexive act (cf. LI II, v, §12b: 101). As Fichte aptly observes, most of the time

we do not notice (*bemerken*) ourselves as the thinker of the object. That is, we do not notice that we are the thinker of the object but rather disappear, so to speak, in the object.

FICHTE (1964): 29

This is why Husserl and Sartre in their early work argue that self-consciousness is not ubiquitous, but consciousness has primacy over self-consciousness. The “I” is nothing special [*Einzigartiges*] floating above experience (see LI II: v §4, 86; LU II/1: v §4, 353). It is not that “I have consciousness of this chair,” but “there is consciousness of this chair” (Sartre (1957): 53–4). Prior to that reflection, there is no subject of experience. Experience “belongs to no-one [*ein niemandes Denken*]” (Hua XVI: §13, 41/34) and is anonymous or “impersonal” (Sartre (1957): 36). Zahavi is right to refer to this as the non-egological conception of consciousness. It denies “that every experience is for a subject. It would, in other words, omit any reference to a subject of experience, and simply say there is an awareness of the watching of the movie” (Zahavi (2000): 56). The NEC thus understands consciousness as anonymous.

2 Consciousness Must be a Form of Self-Consciousness

However, Husserl soon realizes (1910/11) that his position is indefensible and he comes to adopt the egological conception of consciousness. As Zahavi rightly observes, the reason “was probably Husserl’s increasing appreciation of Kant. Whereas Husserl was initially strongly influenced by Brentano’s reception of Hume, and shared many of the former’s anti-Kantian views, Husserl’s ongoing conversations with neo-Kantians like Natorp, eventually made him reassess his initial evaluation” (Zahavi: (2021): 270). Indeed, Husserl comes to reiterate Kant’s dictum that “The “*I think*” must be capable of accompanying all my presentations” (Hua III: §57, 109–10/132–33, emphasis added). This is what leads Gurwitsch to claim that here we find “a manifestly egological conception of consciousness” (Gurwitsch (1941): 326). Indeed, Husserl comes to refer to a “splitting of the ego (*Ichspaltung*)” (CM IV: §19, 73/35) and distinguishes between the transcendental and empirical or real, personal ego. The empirical self can be known (represented), but not the “I” that represents the self. Like Kant, Husserl is not referring to two ontologically distinct selves, but to a doubling of the form of consciousness of this “I” [*doppeltes Bewußtsein*]

dieses Ichs].⁴ The former refers to the self that changes through time and the latter, to the reflexive "I" that accompanies all my representations. Husserl thus acknowledges that when we reflect there are two forms of consciousness at play: one refers to the *cogitationes*, the appearing of appearances, the other to an accompanying consciousness which exceeds the *cogitationes* and remains identical and unitary while the appearances are in a constant flux. Echoing Kant, Husserl holds that the transcendental ego "[...] is not something taken for itself and which can be made into an Object proper of an investigation ... the Ego is completely empty ... has no explicable content, is undescrivable in and for itself: it is pure Ego and nothing more" (Hua III: §80, 160/191; cf. CPR A241/B300). The pure ego does not point to anything "substantial." "It is not the kind of identical something that would first have to manifest and prove itself as identical by means of properties" (Hua IV: §24, 104/110). It is nothing in itself and can only be understood as a correlate of experience.

For Husserl there is thus no doubt that as soon as we reflect upon our experiences, there must be a subject who is engaged in the act of reflection which allows her to make judgments such as "I was running after the streetcar" or "this girl in the photo is me." When I report that "I was running after the streetcar," the "I" that is making the judgement stands apart from the content of the judgment, i.e., the fact that "I was running after the streetcar." The thinker and that which is thought are distinct from each other. Gurwitsch is thus right, at least on the reflective level, consciousness is egological insofar as Husserl is committed to the Kantian view that there must be a self, ego or "I think" (I am using these terms interchangeably here) that accompanies all my experiences.

Yet this is not the self that interests Zahavi. Rather he wishes to put forward the claim that an ego (however minimally understood) is also in play on the pre-reflective level. Zahavi draws this insight from the fact that Husserl revised his position by additionally arguing that consciousness cannot be anonymous, but necessarily refers to a subject of experience (cf. Zahavi 2021: 272). This, Zahavi claims, is the *other reason* which leads Husserl to adopt the egological view of consciousness. If this is correct, then consciousness is egological all the way down. If I understand Zahavi correctly this leads him to argue that experience is mine-ly which, I guess, in this context means nothing other than – to keep to the neologisms – that it is egological-ly. It is here that my disagreement begins. I believe it is one thing to argue that experience is necessarily for a subject and quite another to argue that it is egological.

Let me first look at what exactly leads Husserl to change his view. Husserl comes to realize that we can only ever attribute experiences reliably to

4 Cf. Kant (2007): 7:141, fn. 24; 7:149, fn. 31.

ourselves if experience belongs to someone. If it belonged to no-one, as he initially claimed, self-attribution would be arbitrary. Sartre arrived at the same insight: if consciousness did not belong to anyone, we must create a notion of the self out of nothing. But this means that we be “sorcerers for ourselves each time we view our *me*” (Sartre (1957): 82). Husserl (like Sartre later)⁵ soon recognized that this simply cannot be correct: the self is not created *ex nihilo* through reflection. “There can be no question here of arbitrary possibilities of suddenly coming into existence and stepping forth out of nowhere in the accomplishment of an act” (Hua IV: §22, 100/106). Assuming sincerity, I do not attribute actions to myself in an arbitrary manner, rather I believe that they necessarily were mine all along, even if I did not pay attention to them.

This leads Husserl to conclude, that on the pre-reflective level, I am not just conscious of my activities, rather the subject must be conscious of her own experiences. She is self-conscious and it is precisely for this reason that self-attribution is possible. How could I otherwise recall where I was the other day, that I was reading the book or that I was sitting on a bench at the seaside? I may have not been paying attention to all of this at the time, as I was quite engrossed in my book, however, I can nonetheless recall – more or less adequately – certain aspects of that experience. So, when I attend to experience and pass judgment on it, I am not arbitrarily attributing it to myself, but judge that it was “I” who was absorbed in certain activities *all along*. When I reflect, it is obvious to me that I was reading the book at the seaside and not someone else and certainly not no-one. Consciousness to this extent is reflexive; it is a form of self-consciousness. It is because consciousness is necessarily acquainted with itself that I can reflect and attribute experience to myself more or less reliably and can distinguish between my own lived experiences and the lived experiences of others.

Zahavi is clearly right: Husserl departs from his earlier position. Consciousness is necessarily a form of self-consciousness; there cannot be an awareness of a noise downstairs without being aware of that experience. It is absurd to

5 Sartre's main reason for his change of mind is that he believed that we could have no account of “otherness” if it was not distinct from the self:

Formerly I believed that I could escape solipsism by refuting Husserl's concept of the Transcendental “Ego.” At that time, I thought that since I had emptied my consciousness of its subject, nothing remained there which was privileged as compared to the Other. But actually although I am still persuaded that the hypothesis of a transcendental subject is useless and disastrous, abandoning it does not help one bit to solve the question of the existence of Others. Even if outside the empirical Ego there is nothing other than the consciousness of that Ego – that is, a transcendental field without a subject – the fact remains that my affirmation of the Other demands and requires the existence beyond the world of a similar transcendental field (Sartre (1989): 235; emphasis added).

refer to a consciousness that is oblivious of itself or unconscious (cf. Sartre (1947): 62).⁶ As Husserl says "Every act is consciousness of something, but there is also consciousness of every act. Every experience is 'sensed,' is immanently 'perceived' (internal consciousness), although naturally not posited, meant (to perceive here does not mean to grasp something and to be turned towards it in an act of meaning)" (Hua X: Appendix XII, 126/130). Husserl thereby clearly avoids the regress argument, namely, the danger of arguing that consciousness can only be a form of self-consciousness if we can account for a self that is conscious of this self-consciousness. If self-consciousness is based on a reflective act, we would have to say that there is a self that has the awareness of the noise downstairs; and to account for this self, we would need to assume another self that is aware of the self being aware of the noise downstairs and so forth. Husserl believes that this vicious infinite regress can be avoided. We can account for self-consciousness without appealing to a subject that stands apart of experience, namely, without appealing to a subject that has ascribed experience to itself. To quote: "Every 'experience' in the strict sense is internally perceived. But the perceiving of the internal is not an 'experience' in the same sense. It is not itself again internally perceived" (Hua X: Appendix XII, 127/130).

As soon as there is conscious experience, there is an inner awareness that does not involve an additional secondary or higher order act, which, in turn, needs to be perceived by a further act. The awareness is an internal moment of the intentional act itself. It is an intrinsic feature of the act. There is an awareness of repairing a car (i.e., self-consciousness) without any self-directed or self-referring thought, i.e., any consciousness that it is I who is repairing the car. There is an awareness of reading a book without my paying attention to the fact that I am reading it. In other words, there is an immediate awareness or self-consciousness *without self-observation*. Later Husserl calls this inner consciousness a kind of primal consciousness – *Urbewußtsein* (see Hua X: Appendix IX, 118–19/122–23; cf. Hua III: §45, 84/99). All this, by my lights, shows that self-consciousness is transparent and non-egological.

Zahavi reckons otherwise: "if self-awareness were merely a matter of the awareness that an experience had of itself, we would be dealing with a non-egological or subjectless type of self-awareness" (Zahavi (2005): 146). However, Zahavi argues that this "overlooks the *ipseity* of the experiential dimension" (Zahavi (2005): 146); namely, the "for me component" of experience. There must be a "minimal sense of self" present whenever there is self-awareness. In

6 It is simply nonsense to talk about an "unconscious" content that would only subsequently become conscious. Consciousness is necessarily *consciousness* in each of its phases (see Hua X: Appendix IX, 118–19/122–23).

contrast to my view, Zahavi thus claims Husserl's revised position shows that self-consciousness is necessarily minimally egological, as an "inherent 'quality' of *my*ness" (Zahavi (2000): 69) manifests itself. This, says Zahavi, is what Husserl must have had in mind when he says in the quotation above that every "experience" in the strict sense is "internally perceived." If I understand Zahavi correctly, to be "internally perceived" means that I am conscious that experience is *for me* and not just *in me* (cf. Zahavi (2014): 41). It thus involves having a sense of "what it is like for me" as the subject of an event to enjoy that event. To be "internally perceived" thus means drawing a distinction between "(1) what the object is like for the subject and (2) what the experience of the object is like for the subject" (Zahavi (2014): 33).

But this does not seem true to experience (or for that matter to Husserl's account). It seems to me that we are naturally conscious of events taking place, or of our own activities *without* appealing to an ipseity of experience. I am just conscious of my experiences without being *additionally* conscious of a subjective or for-me-ish character of my experience that is distinct from the object that is experienced. To use one of Zahavi's examples, whenever I taste a single malt whisky, I am conscious of tasting the whisky but in having this experience I am not – as Zahavi claims – conscious of a for-me component. Awareness of what it is like to drink whisky, just like the awareness that the whiskey looks tasty, liquid or translucent, does not give me for-meness, i.e., a sense of what the *experience* of the object is like for me, but merely presents me with what the object is like for me.⁷

3 Minimal Sense of Self and Embodiment

Indeed, I find it hard to understand what exactly such a *for me* component would involve. The fact that we are embodied beings may exemplify best what Zahavi must have in mind. Zahavi draws on Husserl's distinction between the way in which we experience the body from within – which he calls the lived body (*Leib*) – and the way in which we experience the body from without – the objective body (*Körper*) – to illustrate what is at issue. As embodied beings, we do not just see our body as having a certain shape and extension, but we feel our body from the inside. We have proprioceptive and kinaesthetic awareness. When I move towards an object, I have the proprioceptive sense of where my body is in space and I am implicitly aware of the position of my limbs relative

7 Here, I am in agreement with Robert Howell and Brad Thompson: these experiences serve to represent the object and not me (cf. Howell and Thompson (2017): 120).

to other parts of my body. Additionally, I have a kinaesthetic awareness with regard to position and orientation. I am aware that I always find myself in a certain location "here" relative to other objects, which are necessarily "over there." As Husserl has it, "Things are over and against me, not-I, foreign to me" (Hua IV: Supplement VI, 317/329). I experience these objects in relation to my embodied perspective as below, right or left and so forth. Indeed, what interests Zahavi is that Husserl regards my bodily awareness as central to object perception: "The experience of anything physical (objects understood in terms of *res extensa* which are real in time and space) presupposes a sense of our living body."⁸ I take it that this shows for Zahavi that my bodily awareness has a "for me" component which necessarily persists over time. It is necessarily "here" and thus accompanies all my representations.

Zahavi arrives at this observation because my bodily sense, as any form of sensing, is necessarily reflexive. When I touch something, I do not just feel the object, but I instantaneously also feel my hand touching. I cannot sense without sensing myself sensing. This is true for all perceptual experience: "[P]erception is correlated to and accompanied by the self-sensation or self-affection of the moving body. Every visual or tactile appearance is given in correlation to a *kinaesthetic experience*" (Zahavi (2002): 16; cf. Hua XI: 14; Hua VI: 108–109/106).⁹ For Zahavi this shows that experience is not only in relation to *me* but also has a distinctive experiential component. Touching, as any form of sensing, points back to myself. Not only does experience occur in relation to me, but it involves a "primitive form of self-reference" (Zahavi (2011): 332).

I disagree. While I concur with Zahavi, that kinaesthetic and proprioceptive awareness are sources of self-specifying information, I do not understand why he thinks it follows that a primitive form of self-reference, or a sense of mine-ness, is necessarily involved. We should avoid what Charles Siewert has aptly coined "the 'conscious-of'-trap" (Siewert (1998): 194). We should not assume that because to think means to think about something, or to be conscious of something happening to me, or because there are different modes in which we can intend an object (we can desire, imagine or perceive it) that there is contemporaneously some sort of qualitative awareness of for-meness. Even

8 "Das Erfahren des Physischen (der Objekte als *res extensae*, als raumzeitlich realer) setzt waltende Leiblichkeit voraus" (Hua vx: Text Nr. 27, 433).

9 It is however questionable whether every form of sensing is equally reflexive. As the anonymous reader has rightly pointed out, "other senses are only indirectly localized in the body." Indeed, as I have tried to show elsewhere, our kinaesthetic and proprioceptive sense of being 'here' cannot always be that easily mapped onto the location of our objective body in the spatio-temporal world (Alweiss (2018)). However, this does not question the fact that sensing is reflexive.

though experience is shaped by the first-person perspective and occurs in relation to me, and even though I am self-conscious, experience is still only about the world and not myself. It does not yet involve the claim that it is also “present in a distinctly subjective manner, a manner that is not available to anybody else” (Zahavi (2014): 41). Prior to reflection there is just the body as the “subject of perception” (Merleau-Ponty (1945): 184 [239]).

Zahavi may counter that nonetheless a primitive form of self-reference must be in play because pre-reflective experience is not just automatic but is structured by an “I can.” My perception of objects involves proprioceptive and kinaesthetic information about my bodily situation in relation to my projects. When I play football, I see a ball as kickable, however, when I just go for a walk and see a ball on a football pitch, it does not invite me to act. My relation to objects is always active and passive. To this extent “*sensations* are subjective, but in quite a different way than acts are. I *have* sensations” (Hua IV: Supplement VI, 317/330). I am subjected to them, but I can also choose to have sensations: kinaesthetic awareness is therefore additionally marked by an “I can.” “I see a tree, I ‘have’ appearances, images. I look the tree over, I touch it all over: I experience courses of movement-sensations (in the eye; or, for touch, in the moving hand), and these lived experiences are not only lived experiences of courses of events but have the character of an ‘I do’” (Hua IV: Supplement VI, 317/330). I am not just affected but *free* to move my body. I can bring objects closer to me and see them from other perspectives. Kinaesthesia in the form of an “I can” constitutes an “if-then” connection, which manifests itself as soon as I see an object from a particular angle. I am aware of the fact that *if* I move, *then* I will be seeing one and the same object from another angle; through movement an object can become reachable, graspable or more distant. In view of this, “[m]y relation to the object is on the one hand receptive and on the other hand definitely productive. The coming-into-view of the images is ‘in my power’; I can also cause the series to break off, e.g., I can close my eyes. But what is not in my power, *if* I allow the kinaestheses to run their course, is having another image come into view. With regard to this, I am purely receptive” (EJ: §19, 90/84).

For all this no reflection is necessary. But there is no suggestion that there is therefore a distinct “for-me” component or that the subject is conscious of itself as a subject of experience either. As Husserl notes, what makes *my* body distinct from other bodies is that it is “an *organ of the will*, the *one and only Object* which, for the will of my pure Ego, is *moveable immediately and spontaneously*” (Hua IV: §38, 152/159). “I can” move my body freely; “I can” perceive the world by means of these movements; and I can use my body to fulfil certain goals. Yet even though Husserl at times refers (as in the long quote above) to the will of “a pure Ego,” no such appeal is necessary to make sense of experience.

The way I use my body is never like a mere instrument. When I want to grasp something, the grasping hand cannot be separated or distinguished from the “I” that wants to grasp because the hand does not just execute my will. Rather in many ways *it is the hand that wills*. The hand at that moment is not just experienced as an object (objective body – *Körper*) but as a subject of action (lived body – *Leib*). To this extent the body perceives, acts and, moreover, wills. No appeal to a self is necessary. Indeed, when the “I” separates itself from its hand, the hand is reduced to a mere tool or object. At that moment the hand threatens to malfunction. I am no longer “just playing the piano,” but I have to control it in advance of every movement I make. I lose the intimate relation to my body and start making mistakes, my movements become awkward – as we say I become “self-conscious”; i.e., conscious of myself as a self by distancing myself from my bodily sense. But prior to this there is just experience.

4 Minimal Sense and IEM

I assume Zahavi would counter that there must however be an immediate familiarity or acquaintance with myself in play. At times he alludes to the phenomenon of immunity to error of misidentification with respect to the first-person perspective (IEM) to show why.¹⁰ The suggestion is that pre-reflective experience is IEM as there is a *qualitative* subjective side of experience that is not subject to doubt and can only be known from the first-person perspective (see Zahavi (2000): 60; Zahavi (1999): 5ff). Zahavi gives the example of having a toothache: “when I am aware of a pain, perception or thought from the first-person perspective, the experience in question is felt immediately, non-inferentially and non-criterially as mine, i.e., I do not first scrutinize a specific perception or feeling of pain, and subsequently identify it as being mine. If I am puzzled, I can neither be in doubt nor mistaken about who the subject of that experience is, and it is nonsensical to ask whether I am sure that I am the one who is puzzled, or to demand a specification of the criteria being used by me in determining whether or not the felt puzzlement is really mine” (Zahavi (2000): 60). There is thus something distinctive about the *qualitative* aspect of experience: it is immediately and non-criterially mine.

So, when Zahavi appeals to our embodiment, he, like Gareth Evans before him, would argue that it is IEM. As Evans has shown with respect to proprioception, it does not make sense to say:

¹⁰ See Shoemaker (1970).

“Someone’s legs are crossed, but is it my legs that are crossed?”; “Someone is hot and sticky, but is it I who am hot and sticky?”; “Someone is being pushed, but is it I who am being pushed?” There just does not appear to be a gap between the subject’s having information (or appearing to have information), in the appropriate way, that the property of being *F* is instantiated, and his having information (or appearing to have information) that *he* is *F*; for him to have, or to appear to have, the information that the property is instantiated just is for it to appear to him that *he* is *F*.

EVANS (1982): 221

The same holds for our kinaesthetic awareness: “none of the following utterances appears to make sense when the first component expresses knowledge gained in this way: ‘Someone is in my bedroom, but is it I?’; ‘Someone is moving, but is it I?’; ‘Someone is standing in front of a tree, but is it I?’” (Evans (1982): 222).

But does this show that a sense of mineness is present whenever I have experience? I do not think so. There is something misleading about Zahavi’s presentation. Surely IEM is not at work on the pre-reflective level, it only manifests itself through reflection.¹¹ What is IEM is *not the content* of experience, but the *judgements* we make *about ourselves*. What counts is not that I have a toothache, but that I cannot be mistaken by misidentifying the person to whom my judgment applies.¹² When I say, “it does not make sense to say someone has a toothache, but is it I?,” then the claim is that I cannot be wrong *that* it is I of whom I am aware, though I may have mistaken a pain in my jaw for a toothache. But all this shows is that *reflective* consciousness of myself *as* a self may not be prone to errors of misidentification relative to the first person, however, no mention is made about the qualitative character of experience prior to reflection. To put it otherwise, there is only IEM when I reflect upon myself and realise that I am the subject of experience.

To return to the pain example: When I have a toothache “I am my pain.” I do not need to ascertain that the pain is mine to know that I am in pain. I feel the pain without needing to identify myself as the subject enduring the pain and without ascribing the experience to myself. I am conscious of the pain but the experience in question is *not* “felt immediately, non-inferentially and non-criterially *as mine*” (Zahavi (2000): 60; emphasis added). There is no for-me component whatsoever. I am just aware of the pain. Groaning “I have pain” just is

11 I am leaving the question unaddressed whether any experience is ever really IEM.

12 Clearly as the rubber hand experiences have shown, it is questionable whether such experiences are IEM (cf. Blanke and Metzinger (2009)).

"being in pain"; I am crying out in pain. Let me put this in another way: When I am reading a book, I am still just engrossed in the plot. I am conscious of reading the book, the plot and the main protagonist and all the events that slowly unravel themselves to me. Indeed, there is an inner awareness of my being conscious of all this. I am self-conscious. I am conscious of the wind blowing through my hair and the sound of the sea; "but neither this being conscious of, nor the inner awareness of being conscious of was in any way experienced as related to my ego. The latter did not appear at all" (Gurwitsch (1941): 327). IEM thus in no way proves that pre-reflective experience is egological.

I must make it quite clear what I am saying and what I am not saying here. I am not denying that I am self-conscious and that experience has its dative or that it is reflexive and indexically structured. But what I am concerned to dispute is that "experiences are characterized by mineness, or for-me-ness" (Zahavi (2014): 20) or that a distinctive *quality* inheres in our "first-personal mode of experiencing" (Zahavi (2015):20), namely, one that gives me a sense that it is distinctly mine "given differently to me than to anybody else" (Zahavi (2014): 39).

5 Mineness and Animals

This must be correct, otherwise we would have to argue that all sentient beings have a sense of self; a view which Zahavi, indeed, defends (see Zahavi (2000): 69). I think it is fairly uncontentious to argue that all sentient beings are to a certain degree subjects of experience as they experience the world from their own egocentric perspective. Even perceptual systems of lower animals require a subject. Moreover, there is some kind of non-conceptual egocentric sensitivity which higher (non-human) animals may display. We may well be able to ascribe propositional perception (and perhaps even thought) to dogs and cats. It is not non-sensical to observe that "Fido sees that his bowl is empty."¹³ Clearly, such animals have some awareness of their egocentric perspective. I assume a cat chasing a mouse is aware that the mouse is not only in front of it but also reachable; it is aware of the noises surrounding it and it probably also operates with a certain kind of kinaesthetic and proprioceptive awareness. At least it can be said that its perceptual content also contains self-related information which the cat makes use of when it interacts with the environment. As Husserl notes: "Just like us, animals, [...] are subjects of a conscious life to the extent that they also have a 'surrounding world' that is given to them with an

¹³ I should like to thank Jim Grant for pointing this out to me.

ontic certainty.... Their pure conscious life understood from an animal point of view is centred and if we refer to a 'subject for consciousness,' there is an analogue to having consciousness ... So, too, the animal has something like an I-structure" (Hua xv: Part III, Appendix x: 177).

The cat is the bearer of the experience and its proprioceptive and kinaesthetic sense informs its relation to the world. If one claims, in line with Zahavi, that proprioceptive and kinaesthetic awareness provide us with a minimal sense of self, then it follows that animals must also operate with a minimal sense of self. Yet I do not believe we can conclude from the fact that the cat is the bearer of experience and, indeed, has a bodily sense that the cat need be aware *that* experience is self-related in order to chase the mouse. It does not experience it *as hers*. The cat may well be aware that the mouse is at a certain distance from it, indeed, it may regard it as reachable; and it may realise that it stands a good chance of catching the mouse if it makes a leap. To this extent it is aware of its own position. This is why it may appear that the cat has something like an "I" structure. But as Husserl suggests it has something like an "I" structure only by analogy. Surely there is no distinctive phenomenal for-me-ness. Its non-conceptual egocentric awareness lacks a full first-person concept. As Kant observes in a letter to Marcus Herz (1789), representations could follow a certain order in the mind of an animal, yet the animal would lack the capacity to ascribe its representations to itself. Kant thus speculates that "they could still (I consider myself as an animal) carry on their play in an orderly fashion, as connected according to empirical laws of association, and thus they could even have influence on my feeling and desire, without my being aware of my own existence" (Kant (1999): 11:52; 26 May 1789). To put it otherwise, "they lack the reflective self-awareness, namely any awareness of a self-as-'I'" (Kant (2007): 7:127). Animals thus may well have a point of view on the objective world which possesses distinctive phenomenal characteristics. However, even if experience is indexically shaped for them, it does not follow that animals therefore have the capacity to take a cognitive attitude toward it (*Stellungnahme*) and ascribe experience to themselves (cf. Baker (1998)). They do not regard their experience as self-related and are not aware of their point of view *as a point of view*. Experience is for the cat but the cat does not experience *as being for it*.

To put the point summarily, just because all conscious experience is for a subject and shaped by her first-person perspective, we have no reason to assume that selfhood or ipseity is involved whenever we are self-conscious. Experience is transparent and world directed. It is not accompanied by a minimal sense of self. For me-ness does not feature in experience: I experience the ball as kickable and to the left to me. I do not additionally experience what this experience

is like for me. It is sufficient to say that I am conscious of these experiences and thus self-conscious. No reference to a minimal sense of self is required.

6 “Return” to Husserl

I do not just happen to disagree with Zahavi’s account of the self but, more importantly, I disagree with Zahavi’s interpretation of Husserl. For I believe that the position I presented above reflects the one Husserl defends. So how do we arrive at such divergent views? It seems the source of the disagreement lies in how we are meant to understand the relation between reflective and pre-reflective consciousness.

Take the following passages which Zahavi cites to prove that, for Husserl, consciousness is necessarily egological.

When I say “I,” I grasp myself in a simple reflection. But this self-experience [*Selbsterfahrung*] is like every experience [*Erfahrung*], and, in particular, every perception, a mere directing myself towards something that *was already there for me*, that was already conscious, but not thematically experienced, not noticed.

HUA XV, 492–493

Whenever I reflect, *I find myself “in relation to” something as affected or active. That to which I am related is experientially conscious, it is already there for me as a “lived experience” in order for me to be able to relate myself to it.*

HUA VII, 196; Zahavi (2010): 326; emphasis added

The question clearly is: how do we understand the claim that “there was already something there for me but not thematically experienced”? In section 26 of Hua IV, Husserl dwells at length on the question how to understand this tacit awareness. Take the following passage as an example:

The Ego can never disappear, it is always present in its acts but in different ways, depending: if they are or if they become acts *in actu*, then the Ego steps forth, as it were, in them; it comes to the light of day, it exercises an active living function, it directs itself, in an active ray, toward what is objective. But if it is, so to say, a latent Ego, then it does not cast an active regard onto something; it does not actively experience or have an effect on, or undergo, anything ... This Ego-structure precisely allows

us and requires us to say that the Ego in the stage of the specifically “unconscious,” of latency, is not a nothing or the empty potentiality of the alteration of the phenomena into ones of Ego-actuality but instead is a moment of their structure. Thus the images of the stepping forth of the Ego, of the being actively directed onto something, and of the stepping back or sinking back into latent have a real [*reell*] meaning.

HUA IV: §22, 100/106

The reference to a “latent Ego” might seem to confirm Zahavi’s interpretation that there is an “actual Ego” in the background, which merely has to step forth in the act of reflection. Indeed, Husserl distinguishes between an actual positing *cogito* and an improper, not actually positing *cogito* (see Hua III: §114, 232/268). The latter remains in the background but is still necessarily “there.” This seems to confirm Zahavi’s claim that “[p]rior to reflection, there is already an I-consciousness that is not seized upon, an unthematic and non-objective consciousness [...] and it is for precisely this reason that the I can essentially reflect on itself at any time, making itself thematic” (Zahavi (2001): 72).¹⁴ If correct, consciousness must be egological all the way down: there is no self-awareness without an awareness of myself as a self, however minimally conceived (see Zahavi (2000): 62).

But this cannot be Husserl’s position. The self is not a “thing” that can be either attended to or suppressed. It is not like a Jack in a box. When we press the button, it appears; once we press the doll down again, it disappears (remaining hidden in the box). When Husserl talks about the “way it is in the background,” he cannot mean that the self or “I” is there in *actuality* as a matter of fact, but must maintain that it is only *potentially* there. “Potentially” means that it is not yet present and *actual*. Something is potential when it has the power (*dynamis*) or capacity (*potentia*)¹⁵ to “be” in some way *other than it is*. Whatever is potential is *not yet actualized*. *Potentia* implies the possibility of *changing* into something which that thing is currently *not*.¹⁶ But this shows that we should not confuse the claim that I have the capacity to take up a first-personal relation to my own conscious experience, with the claim that I have already pre-reflectively taken up my first-person relation. When Zahavi maintains that “experience entails a pre-reflective sense of self” (Zahavi (2011): 328),

14 “When Husserl speaks of an egoless streaming, the term ‘ego-less’ does not refer to the absence of self, rather the term ‘pre-egological’ is meant to indicate that the ego is not participating [in] or contributing [...] in any active way” (Zahavi (2011): 323).

15 Aristotle uses the term *dunamis* (δύναμις) as a concept to contrast it with actuality. Its Latin translation is “potential.”

16 See Aquinas (1975): I, 13, 9.

he assumes that "in order to explain the occurrence of reflection it is necessary that that which is to be disclosed and thematized is (unthematically) *present*, otherwise there would be nothing to motivate and call forth the act of reflection" (Zahavi (2010): 326; emphasis added). Yet Zahavi conflates the power or *capacity* to refer to oneself as a self with the *actualisation* of that capacity (cf. Schear (2009): 99). This may explain why he argues that what is to be thematised is necessarily unthematically present, i.e., actual. Yet all we are referring to is "a disposition on the part of the subject to ascribe thoughts to himself" (Evans (1982): 259), a disposition which has not yet been actualized.

When Husserl thus argues in the above citation that the self lies in the background, I understand Husserl to be telling us something quite different from what Zahavi wants him to say. He is telling us that the "I" does not just remain hidden (in the background) but that the ego is not yet actual. Pre-reflective consciousness, "*lies outside Ego actuality* and yet, as we indicated earlier, it is appertinent to the Ego (*Ichzugehörigkeit*) in so far as it is the field of *potentiality* for the Ego's free acts" (Hua III: §92, 192/226, emphasis added). Until the ego has exercised the freedom to "cast an active regard onto something" (Hua IV: §22, 100/106), there is no ego. The experiences that remain in the background thus "lack the distinctive Ego-relatedness" (Hua III: §80, 160/191). But nonetheless, "they have their share in the pure Ego.... They are *its* consciousness-background, *its* field of freedom" (Hua III: §80, 160/191). I have the disposition to attend to what I am implicitly acquainted with and can direct my attention to it. The "I" to this extent is free, it is free to direct its gaze. If the ray of regard is not directed to experience, the ego is not present or actual, it has not yet made its emergence. The pure ego emerges and becomes actual only in the moment when I attend to my experience and reflect upon it (see Hua III: §37, 65/75). It "*holds sway* only in the performance, in the cogitations proper" (Hua IV: §26, 108/115). It emerges when we distance ourselves from experience and make judgements, however, independently of this activity, it is nothing.¹⁷

This tells us something important about pre-reflective consciousness. We can uphold the claims that experience is indexically structured and that there necessarily is a subject of experience. But it does not follow that we therefore recognize it as such or that it has a for-me component. On the pre-reflective level, there is no conscious reflexive thought. I can experience things without

17 It is questionable whether attentiveness alone brings about ego consciousness. However, this is a topic for another paper. For an excellent discussion of Husserl's account of *reflection* see Jacobs (2016).

being implicitly aware of a for-me component. Self-consciousness is to this extent self-less.

So, to return to the citation that Zahavi draws on (Hua xv, 492–493, see above), I read it the following way: When I grasp myself in a simple reflection, I am directing myself toward something which is already there, namely, experience that is necessarily in relation to my point of view. I am aware of the noise downstairs and the plot of the book. Consciousness is a form of self-consciousness, but I am not yet registering the fact that it is “I” who is hearing the noise or reading a book. Not only have I not yet ascribed this experience to myself and recognised my point of view *as* a viewpoint, but I am not even conscious of a distinctive *quality* inhering to my “first-personal mode of experiencing” (Zahavi (2015): 20). To reiterate the point we made above: experience is about the world and not myself. It does not yet involve the claim that it is also “present in a distinctly subjective manner, a manner that is not available to anybody else” (Zahavi (2014): 41). In other words, on the pre-reflective level, the ego has not yet taken over the responsibility of its ownership. It is non-egological insofar as it is neither in the possession, nor an accomplishment, of an “I.” Here I agree with Dieter Henrich when he argues that we are referring to a “self-less consciousness of self,” namely, a self-consciousness that has not yet been appropriated by a self. No-one at this stage has yet claimed ownership of the self (see Henrich (1971): 23–4).

So, when Husserl refers to the latent ego and the ego stepping back or sinking back, he realises that “[w]e know all this, however, *in reflection*, in which we grasp in retrospection precisely not only individual background lived experiences but also whole stretches of the stream of consciousness which would lack all Ego-activity” (Hua iv: §22, 100/106; emphasis added). It is only retrospectively that we recognize that experience was mine all long, but this does not mean that a sense of mineness or for-meness has already been a feature on the pre-reflective level.

To summarize: I have tried to show that pre-reflective experience, taken by itself, does not provide me with an experiential quality of “mineness” or “for-meness.” However, as the term suggests, the *potentiality for reflection is nonetheless an integral part of pre-reflective experience*. What marks out pre-reflective experience is that we can, in principle, attribute our experiences to ourselves. Reflection brings into relief the fact that we were self-conscious or, to put it otherwise, that there is something called “pre-reflective” consciousness in the first place. Yet this suggests that human self-consciousness is distinct from animal consciousness. Animals cannot reflect and thus do not have the disposition to become aware of themselves as selves. This is why strictly speaking we cannot refer to their experience as pre-reflective, as they lack the capacity

for reflection. The analogy drawn with animals above is therefore slightly misleading. We cannot call animal consciousness pre-reflective unless we wish to argue that animals have the potential for reflection. To avoid anthropomorphism, all we can say is that there is an analogy: animals display similar behaviour to us, yet no further judgements can be made.¹⁸ So what makes human self-consciousness distinctive is that it has the capacity to reflect, a capacity however which is only actualized when we reflect.

7 Embodiment and Others

It is time to get a clear view of the main features of the self. I have argued that it is only when I reflect that I become conscious of myself as a self. It is then and only then that I attribute experience to myself and become aware that certain experiences were mine all along and not yours. But this does not mean that I was implicitly aware that they were mine all along. It is only in *distancing* myself from experience that the self “grasp[s] itself as what it is” (Hua IV: §23, 101/107), namely, an “I” that is distinct from a “thou.” Prior to reflection, there is no awareness of for-me-ness.

Indeed, in his last works Husserl repeatedly shows that embodiment does not confer an awareness of myself as a self or “I” consciousness. This is because Husserl realizes that we only recognise our first-person perspective *as* a perspective if we are aware that there are other perspectives. Taken on its own, my first-person perspective remains egoless – or to put it otherwise, taken on its own, I can never become aware of a “distinctly subjective manner, a manner that is not available to anybody else” (Zahavi (2014): 41).

Husserl illustrates this by asking what my experience would be like if no other perspective was available. To do this he focuses solely on “*what is peculiarly mine*” and abstracts from anything that suggests the existence of other perspectives that are distinct from the sphere of mineness (see CM V: §44, 127/95). Husserl believes once I abstract from everything that is “alien” or “other,” I “find my *animate organism* as *uniquely* singled out” (CM V: §44, 128/97). But when we focus on the sphere of “mineness,” what comes to light, is that nothing remains that can be called “mine-ly.”

¹⁸ Here I depart from Husserl. Husserl has a more teleological reading. He believes that humans are just more advanced species to animals but share similar capacities. My position is here closer to that of Heidegger, as I would say that non-human animals are simply different; they carve up the world in a different way to us.

What remains unaffected is my sense of being “here,” the fact that I find myself inextricably bound to my body and that objects necessarily constitute themselves as “over there” in relation to my lived body. Initially this seems to confirm Zahavi’s interpretation of Husserl, as Husserl refers to a monadic ego and an identical I pole of experience to describe the unique perspective:

I, as the primordial psychophysical Ego, am always prominent in my primordial field of perception, regardless of whether I pay attention to myself and turn toward myself with some activity or other. In particular, my lived body is always there and sensuously prominent.

CM V: §51,143/113

The “I” is always prominent. Even when I do not pay attention to it, the world is necessarily *mine* and in relation to *me* and my sensuously prominent lived body. This seems to support Zahavi’s reading: a sense of mineness or self, however minimal, is already in place.

However, a closer look at Husserl’s writings suggests that this is not quite his position. He insists that when no other perspective is available, there is no sense of ownership: “The ‘I’ has its peculiar ownness in the Thou.... and the ‘I’ is only constituted in contrast to the Thou” (Hua XIII: Beilage XXXIII, 247). To recognise experience *as mine*, to apprehend itself as an “I” or self, the ego requires a Thou. But surely this means other perspectives need to be available *before* experience is exclusively mine or *mine-ly*, that is, “not available to anybody else” (Zahavi (2014): 41). This is why Husserl insists that reference to mineness, or an ego, without a contrasting viewpoint is simply nonsensical. Husserl thereby clearly states that it is wrong to call it an ego “since for it an *alter ego* makes no sense” (Hua XV: 586; also cited by Zahavi (2015): 5). We cannot refer meaningfully to an *ego* or sense of for-me-ness if there is no alter-ego. Without a Thou, we cannot truly refer to an “I.” When Husserl thus refers to an “I” or “ego” in the above quotation, he realises that it must be non-egological, as it can only be an “I” or “ego” by analogy since it has not yet been appropriated. As long as we do not assume the possible existence of other perspectives, the sense of mineness that our living and sensuous body displays must remain completely undifferentiated and unacknowledged.

Husserl thus clearly believes that embodiment, taken by itself, does not confer a sense of mineness, not even a minimal one. I only “gain” this when I realise that there are other beings who, just like me, see the world from their particular vantage-point. It is then and *only then* that I become aware of myself as a self. I no longer just live in my experience but distance myself from it and realise that others equally see their lived body as their centre of orientation. I

become aware that my perspective is just one of many possible perspectives on one and the same world.¹⁹ It is the presence of others in a shared world which allows me to recognise my first-person perspective *as* a perspective. If I was unable to contrast my perspective with another perspective, I would have no way of recognising my point-of-view *as* a point-of-view. Little remains of the thought that I can refer to a perspective at all.

In view of this, Husserl believes “that subjectivity is what it is – an ego functioning constitutively – only within intersubjectivity” (Hua VI: §50, 175/172) and that “self-consciousness and consciousness of others are inseparable” (Hua VI: §71, 256/253). Or as he puts it a bit later in the same text: “Experiencing – in general, living as an ego (thinking, valuing, acting) – I am necessarily an ‘I’ that has its ‘thou,’ its ‘we,’ its ‘you’ – the ‘I’ of the personal pronouns” (Hua VI: §73, 270/335–36). We only become aware of ourselves as selves if other perspectives are available to us. There is no “I” without a “Thou.”

Zahavi thinks otherwise. He argues that “it is quite legitimate to conduct a formal analysis of the relation between selfhood, experiential self-givenness, and the structures of the stream of consciousness without introducing others into the analysis. In fact, as Husserl writes, when it comes to the peculiar mineness (*Meinheit*) characterizing experiential life, this aspect can be understood without any contrasting others” (Zahavi (2015): 7). In view of this, he believes we can draw an analogy between his conception of the minimalistic experiential self and Husserl’s account of the primal “I.” According to Zahavi: by arguing that “the very for-me-ness of experience isn’t constitutively dependent upon others, I not only take myself to be defending a broadly Husserlian outlook. I also think my recent persistent defence of a minimal notion of self, which is directly tied to the subjectivity of our experiential life, can be related to Husserl’s notion of primal I” (Zahavi (2015): 8).

But I think Husserl has made Zahavi’s interpretation questionable. Husserl has shown the opposite: For experience to be “mine-ly” it has to be “different-ly” or “distinct-ly” from the experience of others (cf. Zahavi 2014: 28). After all, Zahavi insists it is “given differently to me than to anybody else” (Zahavi (2014): 39). But can I experience something “different-ly” or “distinct-ly” without contrasting my experience with that of others? How can experience be mine-ly without involving an awareness of myself as a self that is distinct and not just “distinct-ly” (whatever that would mean) from others. Husserl is quite clear on this, as long as we remain unaware of another person’s perspective, this

19 For the purpose of this paper, I will not discuss how Husserl believes knowledge of other minds is possible. For a detailed discussion see (Alweiss (2010)).

“mineness” remains undifferentiated and “non-relational.”²⁰ Experience cannot be mine-ly, without a contrasting point of view.

Indeed, I don’t think Zahavi’s minimal notion of self can be related to Husserl’s notion of primal I. Husserl insists that an originary “I” is prior to any differentiation. That “I am” and that “I live,” he says, is something I know apodictically even though I can never “grasp” this knowledge, since there is no room for analogy or comparison.²¹ It is precisely for this reason that it “is as yet not at all ‘an’ ego which can have other or many fellow egos outside itself” (Hua VI: §19, 84/82). In much of his later work Husserl attempts to make sense of such an originary “I” (*Ur-Ich*) or “mineness,” which precedes any differentiation.²² He refers to a non-contingent ownership and realises that *without reference to another “I,”* it is in many ways indescribable: “The ‘I’ that I attain to in the epoche ... is actually called ‘I’ only by equivocation” (Hua VI: §54b, 184). It has no exemplar, as it cannot be compared with an alter ego. We are referring to a sense of “I” or mineness, which “does not regard itself yet as an ‘I’ amongst many selves” (Hua VI: §19, 84/82; my translation). To this extent it is *neither singular nor plural*, as it has not yet been singled out, identified or recognised. It is anonymous. Husserl compares the “I without community” to a “dreamless sleep.”²³ It would be an “I” that could not function as an “I.” In many ways it would be truly mad (*verrückt*).²⁴ Unlike Zahavi, I thus believe that we do not operate with a “thin” or minimalist experiential self which precedes the formation of a “more complicated and complex self” (Zahavi (2014): 235). But there is only one self, the self that Zahavi calls complex that emerges through reflection.

Zahavi thinks this cannot be the full story, for how can another ego manifest itself if it is not in opposition to an ego, namely, a being that already operates with a sense of self?²⁵ “The preservation of such an autonomous sphere of subjectivity must be considered a presupposition for any coherent theory

20 Heidegger uses this expression in relation to our understanding of being-toward-death.

21 For an excellent account of the *Ur-Ich* see Held (1966) and Taguchi (2006).

22 We are therefore referring to a sense of I or individuality that is without exemplar. As Husserl elucidates: “The ‘I’ is completely individual (individuell): “*Ein Ich – ist nicht Ich. Ich habe nicht neben mir ein zweites, von dem ich sagen koennte: das bin ich. Das ist rot – das ist auch rot, das ist ein Haus – das ist ein anderes Haus. Das ist Ich – ein Ich, das ist auch ein Ich. Aber wir sagen nie: ein Ich. Man kann so eigentlich nicht sagen, wenn Ich eben Ich bedeutet. Man kann sagen: ‘ein Mensch und ein anderer Mensch’, aber eigentlich nicht ‘ein Ich und ein anderes Ich’. Ich ist absolut individuell*” (Ms B I 14/138a cited by Marbach (1974): 159). (Cf. Alweiss 2010 & 2012).

23 Cited by Smith (2008) and Zahavi (2001): 112.

24 Cf. Marbach (1974): 331.

25 “Intersubjectivity is first and foremost a relation between subjects, or more correctly put, it is first and foremost a relation between me and the other or others. Without a careful

of intersubjectivity” (Zahavi (2015): 9; cf. Zahavi (1996): 68). Indeed, Sartre and Husserl addressed precisely this conundrum when they moved away from their original positions. As we have shown above, both realised that consciousness must belong to someone – i.e., it must be a form of self-consciousness – otherwise we could not account for the possibility of self-attribution. It would not allow us to differentiate reliably my experience from that of others. This is what led both Husserl and Sartre to claim that consciousness is necessarily a form of self-consciousness; it must belong to “someone” and cannot just belong to “no-one” as they initially claimed. Yet as I have shown, Zahavi ignores the distinction between consciousness and self-consciousness and jumps to the conclusion that either consciousness belongs to no-one and is non-egological or it is a form of self-consciousness which goes hand in hand with a basic sense of for-me-ness and is therefore egological (see, e.g., Zahavi (2015): 7). Belonging to someone means, for Zahavi, that we have a pre-social form of self-experience.

But I believe Husserl’s account proves something quite different. It is not that there is a minimal sense of self that allows us to make sense of others; rather the claim is more radical, that the identification of an “I” and “Thou” are contemporaneous and both are a result of reflection. Self-experience is *not* a precondition for other-experience (see Zahavi (2015): 11), but self-consciousness is the precondition for the experience of myself as a self as distinct from others, **and** the experience of others as distinct from me. To this extent the distinction between self and others, as Merleau-Ponty, rightly observes is rooted in a common anonymity of the original “I” which is completely undifferentiated and non-relational (see Merleau-Ponty (1964): 174 [220]; cf. Held (1966): 151–163). It is in other words, non-egological.

We can thus conclude with Hölderlin, judgment (*Urtheil*) stands for an originary (*Ur*) splitting (*teilen*): “Judgment: is in the highest and strictest sense the original sundering of Subject and Object [...] the very sundering which first makes Object and Subject possible, the *Ur-Theilung*” (Hölderlin (1795): 515). Prior to that judgment there is no self that stands apart from or accompanies experience. I only become aware of myself as a self (self-conscious in the strict sense) “because I oppose myself to myself; I sunder myself from myself” (Hölderlin (1795): 515). “I am I” is the most appropriate example for this concept of *Urtheilung*: it [the ego] posits itself as opposed to the Non-ego, not to itself. The splitting of the self or distancing is thus necessarily secondary. It is possible only if there was something unitary initially (*das Ganze, das Seyn*). A unitary whole where there is no distinction between mine and thine. The

and judicious account of the first-person perspective involved, the whole enterprise will fail” (Zahavi (2015): 8).

original unity and being is nothing other than the common anonymity of the original I which is completely undifferentiated. It is non-egological.

8 Doubling of the Self

Contrary to Zahavi, I wish to argue that Husserl operates with a narrower conception of self. I only have a sense of self when I distance myself from my experience and see the world from a viewpoint that is distinct from mine. This, indeed, defines what makes us humans distinct (from other sentient beings). An animal, Husserl claims, only lives in the present: "It is questionable whether animals can remember and make present again, or indeed can phantasise in the same way as we can."²⁶ Only we can bring experience back into the present and therefore can ascribe certain experiences to ourselves. This is possible only through acts of self-remembrance and self-phantasy. I can re-present myself and recognise myself as myself. Hector-Neri Castañeda calls this an indirect reflexive (X believes that he himself is F). (See Castañeda (1967)). It is the capacity to see myself as myself (at a distance) and yet at the same to be identical with myself. We humans have the capacity to repeat (see Marbach (1974): 338) and therefore make ourselves present to ourselves.

It is time to get a clearer picture of this capacity of self-division. It is through recognition, recollection and imagination, that I am able to relate one event to another. What I do in these instances is synthesize different acts. Here Husserl is in full agreement with Kant: it is in and through the act of synthesis that the pure ego emerges. As Kant observes: "empirical consciousness ... the identity of the subject ... does not yet [*noch nicht*] come about by my accompanying each representation with consciousness, but only insofar as I *conjoin* one representation with another, and am conscious of the synthesis of them" (CPR B133; translation slightly altered and emphasis added).²⁷ That is to say, awareness of myself as an *identical* subject comes about only thanks to synthesis and the activity of an "I think," and so only with reflection (I shall return to this below). As Eduard Marbach has shown, it is only at these moments when the subject displaces herself from her present situation and relates her experiences to past and future ones that the pure ego emerges. This shows that

26 "Man kann hier fragen: Haben die Tiere eigentliche Wiedererinnerungen, anschaulich wiederholende, und haben sie anschauliche Phantasievorstellungen im selben Sinne wie wir?" (Marbach (1974): 335).

27 I should like to thank Steve Kupfer for drawing my attention to this. Kemp-Smith leaves out the "not yet" in his translation.

experience as such is not egological, but it only becomes so through such acts of synthesis and self-division.²⁸

Something important has come to light: pre-reflective embodied experience may well be central to self-consciousness. But this does not mean that it is central to our notion of self. On the contrary, what marks out the self is that it is able to distance itself from itself and can divorce itself from its own embodied situatedness. Husserl, indeed, insists the pure Ego is without a Body (see Hua IV: §22, 97/103). Husserl calls it a spiritual self: “‘spiritual’ here is used in a mere general sense, referring to ‘the Ego’ that has its place precisely not in Corporality [*Leiblichkeit*]; e.g., I ‘think’ (*cogito*), i.e., I perceive, I represent in whatever mode, I judge, I feel, I will, etc., and I find myself thereby as that which is one and the same in the changing of these lived experiences as ‘subject’ of the acts and states” (Hua IV: §22, 97/103). It is distinct or stands apart from lived experiences. This is why Husserl refers to it as a “transcendence within immanency” (Hua III: §57, 110/133). But prior to this distancing (transcendence) there is no self, not even a minimal one.

9 Mineness and Kant

Zahavi wants it to be otherwise. He believes there must be a “transcendence vis-à-vis my experiences” (Zahavi (2011): 325) even on the pre-reflective level as “we can distinguish the plurality of changing experiences from the *abiding* dative of manifestation” (Zahavi (2011): 325; emphasis added). By my lights, Zahavi thereby fails to realize the full extent to which Husserl has departed from Kant. When Husserl in the *Logical Investigations* argues we need not appeal to an ego to account for experience, the reason was that he believed that experience as such is structured and saturated with meaning. We do not see what James calls a “blooming buzzing confusion” which needs to be structured by a self or ego. But, Husserl argues, “I see a thing, this box I do not see my sensations” (LU II/1 v §14: 382; LI/2: 104); “I do not see colour-sensations but coloured things, I do not hear tone-sensations but the singer’s song” (LU II/1 v §11:374; LI/2:99). It is this insight that leads him to argue that experience is non-egological, i.e., once we return to the things themselves as they show themselves, we realise

28 It is surprising that Zahavi draws on Marbach’s work, however only to arrive at an opposite conclusion. He believes that Marbach shows that consciousness must be egological all the way down, for otherwise it is impossible to give an adequate account of intersubjectivity (see Zahavi (2005): 4ff.). Yet Marbach, just like me, only claims that Husserl has abandoned the view that consciousness belongs to no-one and not that consciousness is non-egological.

we do not need to appeal to an abiding self to make sense of experience (cf. LI II v. §4:86). Husserl, I believe, never revoked this claim.

Neither, it appears, does Zahavi. Indeed, Zahavi tirelessly questions the “classical view that we need to appeal to a self in order to account for [... the, LA] unity” of experience. Zahavi summarises the classical view as follows: “To think of a simultaneous or temporally dispersed plurality of objects is to think of myself being conscious of this plurality, and this requires an *undivided, invariable, unchanging* me. On such an account, the unity of self is taken to be something with explanatory power rather than something that itself is in need of an explanation. The classical term for this principle of organization and unification is transcendental ego” (Zahavi (2011): 314; emphasis added). Zahavi argues that this view errs insofar as “it is not the ego which unifies the experiences” (Zahavi (2011): 321). So Zahavi is quite clear, the claim that experience is necessarily mine should not be confused with claim that an ego needs to account for the unity of experience. It has no explanatory power.

Surely this means that Husserl’s account of pre-reflective consciousness must be non-egological. Zahavi agrees with the premise but not the conclusion. To cite Zahavi at length, he agrees with the premise that Husserl continues to claim that: “there is no ‘I’ or spontaneous ‘I think’ that brings about the unity of consciousness.” (cf. Husserl (2004): 110). “As he repeatedly emphasizes, the most fundamental constitutive synthesis of them all, the very process of temporalization, is a purely passive process that is by no means controlled by the ego.” (Husserl (2011): 368). Indeed, as Husserl famously puts it, a “structural analysis of the primal present (the standing living stream) leads us to the ego-structure and to the constant substratum of egoless streaming which founds it” (Hua xv: 598m; cited by Zahavi (2021): 273).

But Zahavi disagrees with the conclusion. Zahavi does not think this proves that consciousness is non-egological but he suggests that even if there is no need to appeal to an ego to make sense of experience, experience must be egological. In other words, although Husserl refers in the above passage to an “egoless streaming,” Zahavi contends that Husserl must nonetheless claim that consciousness is egological, as he comes to realize that it is necessarily *for someone*. “When Husserl speaks of an egoless streaming, he believes that the term ‘ego-less’ does not refer to the absence of self, rather the term ‘pre-egological’ is meant to indicate that the ego is not participating [in] or contributing [...] in any *active* way” (Zahavi (2011): 323). The point for Zahavi is that “even though the process is not initiated or controlled by the ego, it still happens to somebody, rather than nobody. Or to rephrase it in the first-person, even if the process is not initiated or controlled by me, it still happens to me” (Zahavi: 2021). But as I have shown, this claim in itself does not render consciousness

egological. If anything, it just makes a conceptual claim that experience must be for someone. But Zahavi wants to say more: he wishes to argue that because experience is owned, or has its dative, we must have a sense of an *abiding and permanent* ownership.

It is this claim that I feel is problematic: it must endorse the classical view and give the self an *explanatory* power. As Zahavi admits: "to think of a dispersed plurality I must think of myself as being conscious of that plurality and this requires an undivided and unchanging me" (Zahavi (2011): 314). In other words, my experiences are experienced as unified *only insofar* as there is a "property *common* to all my experiences" (Zahavi (2011): 324 emphasis added), and this common property has a *function*: it allows for the unity of consciousness. While mineness, unlike the Kantian "I think," does not refer to an active principle that stands apart from experience, Zahavi's account still remains Kantian in spirit as Zahavi believes that Husserl accepts Kant's claim that I can only account for a unity of experience if I have a *permanent* sense of ownership over time. We are not far off the classical view: while the self does not actively unify experience, or stand apart from experience, there is still "some relation between self and unity" (ibid). As Zahavi admits, the "unity is constituted by first-personal self-givenness" (Zahavi (2011): 327). Clearly this questions Husserl's observation that experience is unified without needing to appeal to a permanent and identical self to make sense of experience.

While Zahavi repeatedly insists that he is in agreement with Husserl and thus "rejects the view that it is the self or ego which unifies the stream of consciousness" (Zahavi (2011): 323n), I believe he fails to act upon what he preaches. Once again, I must make clear what I am not saying. I am not questioning Zahavi's, or for that matter, Husserl's claim that experience is necessarily reflexive, insofar as it is perspectival and for someone. What I am concerned to dispute is the constitutive role that Zahavi attributes to the self by insisting that we necessarily *experience* a distinctive, persistent and permanent sense of mineness. It is the latter claim that Husserl questions when he argues that experience is non-egological. It is non-egological as it is sufficient for experience to be for me or in relation to me, I do not need to be additionally conscious that I am the same and identical self having these experiences (cf. CPR 133).

It is important to remember why Kant insists it is necessary that we are conscious of our ownership. Kant is committed to the view that I only experience something *as* an object when I cognise the representation *as "my own"* (CPR B134–5), i.e., when it has been endorsed by an "I think." Kant is here stating more than the conceptual truth that experience is for a subject, or that experience is mine. Kant wants to argue that to experience a certain representation, say "A," as passing from one state "A1" to another "A2," it is not sufficient for the

representation “A1” to be mine and for the representation “A2” to be mine, but I need to recognize that I am each time the *same* subject experiencing “A1” and “A2.” It is only then that I recognize A to be passing from one state to another.

In other words, to know that A1 precedes A2, I must be conscious that the “I” that thinks A1 is the same as the “I” that thinks A2. I only recognize the order because I recognise that I am one and the same subject that is experiencing that order. So, for Kant it is not sufficient to say that there is a relation between A1 and A2 and that both are *for me* and “stand together in a universal self-consciousness.” (CPR B132). It is not sufficient because he believes that this relation is *nothing to me* if I am not conscious that I am the same and identical subject thinking (which for him means combining or synthesising) this order. For Kant the issue is thus that we need to run through the individual moments and recognise them to be mine. I am only conscious of the objective connection if I identify myself with the “I” that thinks A1 and the “I” that thinks A2. As Allison has put it aptly, without the “I think,” I would merely be referring to a connection in me but not a connection for me (Allison (2004): 60; (2015): 344), i.e., I would not be conscious of the connection *as* a connection (cf Alweiss 2014).

I do not see how Zahavi departs from these claims. To the contrary, he seems to repeat the view that I need to be conscious that experience is *for me* (i.e. objective) and not just *in me* (i.e. subjective) (cf. Zahavi (2014): 41), and for Zahavi this means that I must have a sense of an *abiding* ownership – the “persisting dative of manifestation.” Indeed, he endorses the symmetry thesis: 1) The identity of the subject comes about only insofar as I recognize that I am one and the same subject having these representations and 2) this is possible only if these representations are of something objective. Seen in this light, Zahavi merely replaces the “I think” that must accompany all my representations with the sense of *miness* or *for-me-ness*, but structurally all remains the same. But if this is the case, it is hard to see how Zahavi can still claim that he agrees with Husserl that experience is already unified, as he seems to agree with Kant after all: the self, however minimally conceived, plays a constitutive role.

But by my lights when Husserl argues that meaning or unity is given, he is questioning the symmetry thesis. He wishes to argue that to know that A1 precedes A2, I must be self-conscious: there cannot be a consciousness of something *as* an object without being conscious of this experience. “Every act is consciousness of something, but there is also consciousness of every act” (Hua X: Appendix XII, 126/130). Indeed, in each instance experience is mine. It is in relation to me and my activities, projects and interests. It belongs to one and the same subject. But contrary to Kant, I think Husserl is committed to the view that the relation between A1 and A2 is *something to me* even if it is not

endorsed by an "I think." I do not need to run through the individual moments and recognise them to be in relation to a *persisting* sense of mineness, as unity constitutes itself in the object and is not brought about by the subject. The novelty of Husserl's position is thus that I can be conscious of the objective connection without needing to identify myself with the "I" that thinks A₁ and the "I" that thinks A₂. This is why the self has no explanatory power. I can have experience without recognizing it as mine or, for that matter, experiencing it as mine, namely, without have a sense of a persisting or abiding ownership. This is why consciousness is non-egological: it is neither in the possession of, nor an accomplishment of an "I." Self-consciousness is self-less insofar as no-one at this stage has yet claimed ownership.

Zahavi may retort that in the end our positions are not that different. After all, we both agree that experience is for me and reflexive. Indeed, we both argue that self-attribution and any kind of reflection, is possible only on the basis of pre-reflective experience. It is just that I maintain that pre-reflective consciousness is a necessary but not sufficient condition for selfhood whereas Zahavi claims that it is already an aspect that furnishes our conception of selfhood. This explains why Zahavi conception is more multi-layered. Seen in this light, one could thus argue that our dispute is nothing more than a terminological quibble. But at issue here is more than that. I believe Zahavi fails to recognize the significance of Husserl's departure from Kant, namely, that we do not need to appeal to an ego-principle or sense of abiding ownership to account for the unity of experience. The point is, on the pre-reflective level I am, as Henrich would say, my consciousness, i.e., I am self-conscious but not a self that owns its consciousness. And the novelty of Husserl's position is that I do not need to own it, or have a sense of abiding ownership, to have experience.

In the end I believe Zahavi imputes something to experience, which he thinks *must* be there. This is because he believes that we *need* to assume a sense of mineness or ownership, to account for the experience of otherness or the unity of experience, and to explain how self-attribution is possible. It is these theoretical concerns that lead Zahavi to impose something to experience that is not there. But, as I have tried to show repeatedly, when we return to the things as they show themselves, we do not experience a separate or distinct sense of ownership. Experience is transparent, outside in the world among other people. Sartre must be right: "in vain would we seek the caresses and fondlings of our intimate selves [...] like a child who kisses his own shoulder – for everything is finally outside: everything, even ourselves. Outside, in the world, among others. It is not in some hiding place that we will discover ourselves; it is on the road, in the town, in the midst of the crowd, a thing among things, a human among humans" (Sartre (1939): 5).

Acknowledgement

This paper is dedicated to Steven Kupfer. We had endless discussions about this topic. Steve has been a mentor and friend for a large part of my life. The world without him is no longer the same. I should also like to thank the many readers of this paper. Jim Grant for reading and discussing this paper on multiple occasions. Klaus Held, Rudolf Bernet, Burt Hopkins, Christopher Erhard and the anonymous reader of this paper, whose comments made me reflect on some of the central issues I address. I should also like to thank Samantha Fazekas for editing the final version of this text.

Abbreviations

CPR *Immanuel Kant's Critique of Pure Reason*. Translated by Norman Kemp Smith. London: Macmillan Press, 1933.

Abbreviations used for Edmund Husserl:

All references give the page number of the HUSSERLIANA (Hua) first.

Please note that the page numbers in the marginalia of the English translation of Hua III refer to the 1913 (Tübingen: Max Niemeyer) edition.

Unless it is indicated otherwise, I have made only the following two amendments to the published translations: 1) I have translated the term *Erlebnis* as “lived experience” and not as “mental process”; 2) I have translated the term *Leib* as “lived body” and not as “Body.”

CM *Cartesian Meditations – An Introduction to Phenomenology*. Edited by S. Strasser. Translated by Dorion Cairns. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1960. [*Cartesianische Meditationen und Pariser Vorträge*. Edited by S. Strasser, 1950. The main text has been edited and individually published by Elisabeth Ströker: Hamburg: Meiner Verlag, 1987].

EJ *Experience and Judgment: Investigations in a Genealogy of Logic*. Translated by James S. Churchill and Karl Ameriks. Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1973. [*Erfahrung und Urteil, Untersuchungen zur Genealogie der Logik*. Edited by Ludwig Landgrebe, with an afterword and index by Lothar Eley. Hamburg: Meiner Verlag, 1985, sixth revised edition].

Hua III *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy. First Book: General Introduction to a Pure Phenomenology*. In *Edmund Husserl Collected Works*. Volume II. Translated by F. Kersten. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1983. [*Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und*

- phänomenologischen Philosophie, Erstes Buch: Allgemeine Einführung in die reine Phänomenologie* (1913), revised and extended edition based on Husserl's handwritten marginalia. Edited by Walter Biemel, 1950].
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- LI *Logical Investigations.* Translated by J. N. Findlay. London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1970. Vols. I & II.
- LU Hua XVIII–XIX/1–2; originally published as *Logische Untersuchungen*. Tübingen: Max Niemeyer Verlag, second revised edition.

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